Statement of Teaching Philosophy

Introduction

One of the hardest things I have done is teach a 6pm undergraduate class, mid-Winter. Some students are fatigued from having classes all day, some are just getting off work, and everyone is looking forward to the warmth of their beds considering that it's already been dark since 5 pm due to daylight saving. However, my once abstract teaching philosophy was solidified through this experience, making that class one of my most memorable and wonderful accomplishments. As a teacher of technical and professional communication (TPC) with knowledge of digital humanities (DH) methods, my teaching style is anchored on an inclusive learning model built on engagement, universal design for learning (UDL), interdisciplinary experimentation, and AI literacy aimed at improving learning for the entire class and building representation, access, and community.

Engagement

My classroom prioritizes engagement by encouraging students to ask diverse questions across spectrums and advancing a flipped classroom. On the one hand, at the beginning of the semester, I advise students to ask me "stupid" questions. I have realized that many times students don't ask questions because they feel that their peers may look down on the question or the instructor may perceive them as being dumb, whereas this is not the case. I emphasize that the questions they are genuinely confused about but think may sound *stupid* are exactly the type of questions I want to hear. I prove this by making room for interactive and randomized questions during lessons. On the other hand, my syllabus design incorporates materials and texts that students are assigned prior to a class. By flipping the classroom, students engage in discussions and practice exercises based on their comprehension of the assigned readings. Hence, students can relate their diverse social and academic backgrounds and experiences to the contributions they make in class, the topic they engage with, as well as the questions they raise. Students valued this invitation to ask questions and noted that it also helped them pay closer attention during class.

Universal Design for Learning

Also, I advance UDL via multimodality to facilitate access to multiple modes of learning and participation. Diverse students have diverse bodies and abilities; multimodality foregrounds each student's experience and creates an equitable classroom environment. UDL provides access to multiple means of engagement, representation, and expression. For me, UDL is evidenced by the accessible slides I prepare for each class, the multiple platforms I incorporate for composition and other class activities that encourage play, and how I prioritize students' goals and expectations for the class.

Experimentation

Significantly, I encourage experimentation that gives students room to work in and with emerging technologies across their respective fields and interests. This experimentation is grounded in DH methods and principles of inquiry, ethics of care, and social justice. Since my class incorporates students from diverse majors, the class assignments and activities, including group projects are tailored to accommodate diverse interdisciplinary, multidisciplinary, and transdisciplinary perspectives. This is made possible by foregrounding DH methods and introducing students to the fundamental concepts and principles of DH. This allows them to approach diverse fields from a humanistic lens by incorporating ethics of care and working towards social justice.

AI Literacy

Additionally, artificial intelligence (AI) is not prohibited from the classroom. Personally, experimenting with AI tools from a humanistic lens has improved my creativity and made coding accessible. Under instructors' guidance, I have used AI in ethical and efficient ways to create a digital portfolio, as well as a web-based and local tool for data analysis. Research shows that DH and TPC scholars and practitioners need to develop AI literacy skills to effectively understand and explain its risks as well as consider how roles are likely to be augmented, replaced, and even emerge. Hence, the class activities and curriculum is designed to help students cultivate AI literacy skills that will make them critical users of AI and other digital tools within and outside the classroom.

Conclusion

Since the syllabus is designed to accommodate students' interests, foster inclusive and playful pedagogy, and provide a guided approach towards AI use, despite challenges such as fatigue, students in my classroom tend to excel because of the diverse platforms and opportunities available for flexible, active, and collaborative participation. Consequently, while engagement with the rubric is a consideration for major assignments, grades primarily reflect students' levels of participation. Overall, students develop both digital and critical digital literacy skills relevant to their respective disciplines and grounded in humanistic principles emphasizing interpretive knowledge and ethics of care; and the multiple modes of engagement enable students to effectively participate without feeling fatigued through the class, as during a routine observation, my supervisor noted that my students were surprisingly alert for an evening class.